

End Paper



"THE TUNNEL"

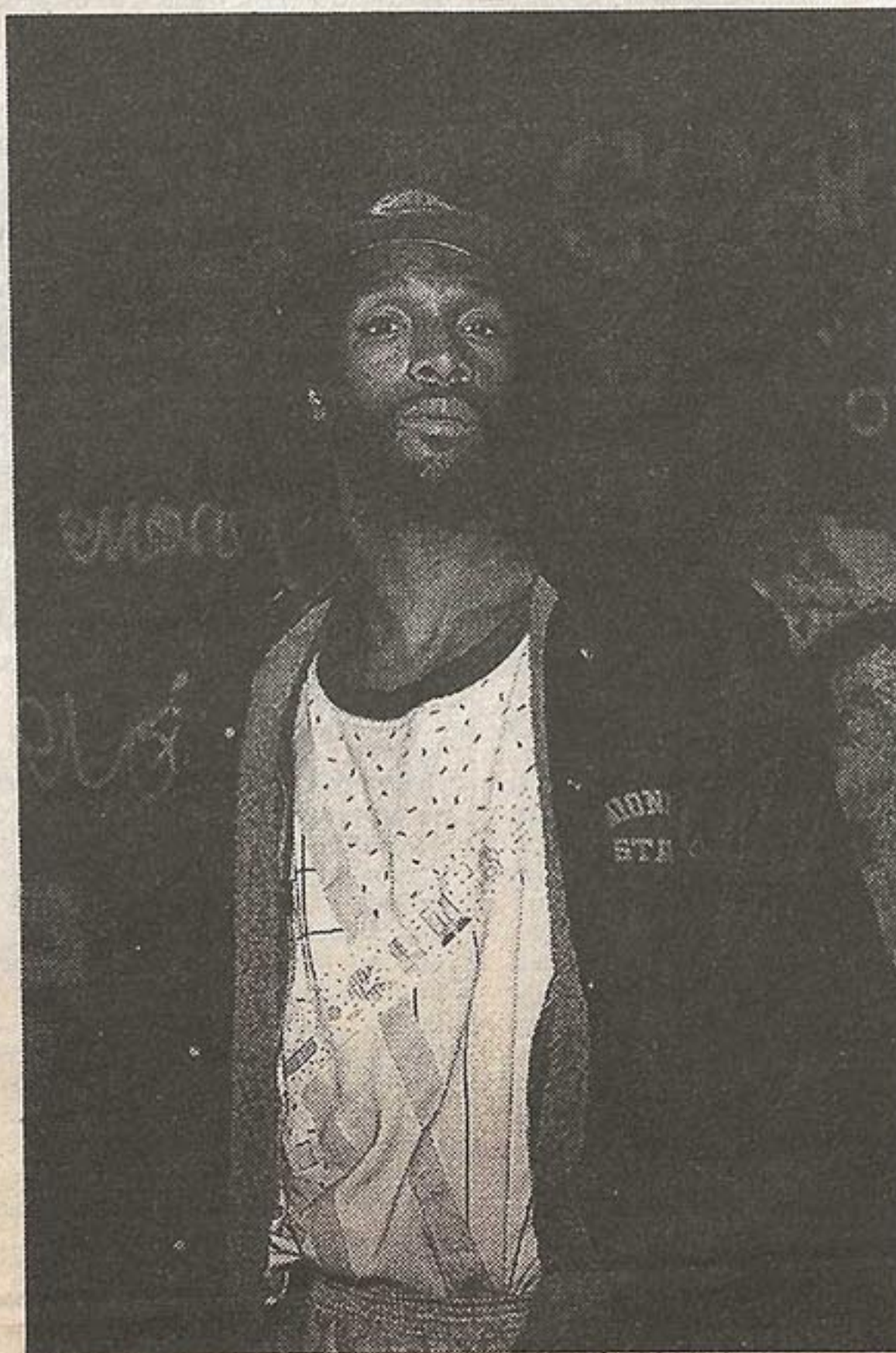
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The Will to Be

JUNE 7TH, 1985, was the official day I first came to the abandoned train tunnel to dwell. . . . And till this day I still say it's probably the greatest thing that I've done in my life—it is.

I have no regrets. I didn't plan on it going into [ten] years but that's the way life is. You make no plans sometimes. In most cases our decisions are to make more money, to acquire more things, material things and what. This existence has done so much for me. It's taken me from the vanity. I was just amazed at how I adapted to it. . . .

I envisioned that when I leave here that I was gonna leave something behind. I was eating a pear last week, and it was very ripe. And I tore it open and there was a seed part, and so I took the hole, like a cavity, and dug it out. And I planted the hole part right in the ground. I hope it grows. I'd like to leave something like a plant or tree behind and one day probably



"BERNARD"

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return here and say, "Wow, my tree has grown." That would be great to see. . . .

There's a certain level of consciousness required of man. And one can't perfect that within functional society. You have to basically be separated and apart from it. And I guess that's why I'm going through what I'm going through. I've been put into a hell of an environment to try and perfect this. But by the same token, it's a perfect environment. It's all about one's focus and one's will to be.

—Bernard Monte Isaac

The photographs and text are from the book The Tunnel: The Underground Homeless of New York City, by photographer Margaret Morton, who spent six years photographing and recording oral histories of homeless people in New York City. Ms. Morton is an associate professor of art at Cooper Union. Copyright © 1995 by Margaret Morton, published by Yale University Press. Reproduced by permission.